

Eurasian otter

Lutra lutra



Webbed feet and the ability to close their ears and noses underwater may mark them out as a semiaquatic member of the weasel family, but oddly enough, Eurasian or common otter cubs are not naturally drawn to water. In fact, female otters often have to drag their protesting cubs in for their first swim at around 16 weeks of age. However, once the initial shock has worn off, they quickly learn to love the water, spending hours play-fighting together in the shallows near the holt, or den, where they were born.

Staying dry

Once grown, their double-layered coats trap air bubbles for insulation in frigid waters, and the waterproof outer layer keeps them dry. Slender bodies and thick, tapered tails make them extremely graceful swimmers, highly skilled at catching fish. They eat shellfish (particularly crabs), amphibians, and even water birds such as ducks. The year that the cubs spend with their mother is the

longest time Eurasian otters live in a group. Otherwise, aside from mating, when a male and female may spend a week or so together, these highly vocal mammals lead solitary lives, staking out territories of 1–4 miles (1.6–6.4 km) along rivers, estuaries, lakes, streams, and ocean shores. Otters mark their territories with spraints, or droppings, usually on top of rocks, driftwood, or other debris near the water’s edge.

On the lookout

Spraints and tracks are often the only signs of these highly vocal carnivores, because acute hearing, smell, and sight mean otters are more likely to be alert to a human being’s presence and duck out of sight before the latter is aware they were ever nearby. The positioning of their eyes, ears, and noses toward the top of the head also means they can keep their bodies hidden from view underwater while they watch, until the coast is clear.

↔ 23–28 in (57–70 cm)

⚖ 15–22 lb (7–10 kg)

⊗ Near threatened

🐟 Fish, ducks, water voles

Europe, Asia

Otters that **hunt in coastal waters** need fresh water to **remove salt from their coat**



◁ **CLEAR VIEW**
Thick, double-layered fur keeps otters warm in icy conditions, and their long whiskers, called vibrissae, help them to locate prey in murky water.



△ **FRESH CATCH**
Fish make up about 80 percent of a Eurasian otter’s diet. Adults eat up to 15 percent of their body weight in fish per day.

◁ **UNDERWATER DIVE**
Although the Eurasian otter is an exceptionally agile swimmer, it cannot hold its breath for long. Average dives last no more than 30 seconds.